

"Holiday Kidney Syndrome"

Surviving Fiestas, Reunions & the Holidays with CKD

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Every December and every fiesta season, kidney patients are rushed to emergency rooms — and some die — because of food, drinks, and skipped dialysis sessions at celebrations. We call this pattern "Holiday Kidney Syndrome." It is preventable. This pocket companion is the plan: what to eat, what to skip, how to protect your dialysis schedule, and when to go to the ER.

The one-sentence version

Enjoy the party — but plan your plate, count your fruit, budget your fluid, take your medicines, and never, ever stretch your dialysis gap for a celebration.

The Most Dangerous 72 Hours of the Year

THE LONG GAP RISK

Skipping or delaying dialysis during the holidays can be dangerous.

Extra food, drinks, and busy schedules can lead to fluid overload, high potassium, and other life-threatening complications.



Don't let a few missed sessions become an emergency.

WHAT CAN HAPPEN WITH LONG GAPS?



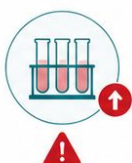
FLUID OVERLOAD

Leads to swelling, shortness of breath, and high blood pressure.



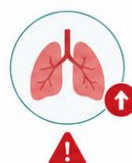
HIGH POTASSIUM

Can cause dangerous irregular heartbeats or even cardiac arrest.



TOXIN BUILD-UP

Waste in the blood can cause nausea, weakness, and confusion.



BREATHING PROBLEMS

Too much fluid in the lungs can make it hard to breathe and may require hospital care.



HOSPITALIZATION RISK

Skipping sessions can turn the holidays into a medical emergency.



PLAN AHEAD. STAY SAFE.

- ✓ Keep your dialysis schedule — even during the holidays.
- ✓ If you must travel, coordinate with your dialysis center in advance.
- ✓ Follow your fluid and diet plan.
- ✓ When in doubt, **don't miss. Call.**



Your best gift this season?

Sticking to your dialysis plan.

It keeps you strong for the moments that matter.



Every patient is different. Talk to your nephrologist about your holiday dialysis plan.



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- **The long gap** — on a 3x/week schedule you already have one 2-day gap. Large studies (32,065 patients) show the day after it is the deadliest day of the week: +23% deaths, +77% heart-failure admissions, +90% dangerous heart rhythms.
- **Holidays stretch the gap** — a closed unit or a "moved" session turns 2 days into 3-4 — and the feast lands exactly when your body has no way to remove potassium and fluid.
- **No cheat days in kidney failure** — what you eat waits in your blood until your next session. There are only portions you planned and portions you will regret.

The two golden rules

1) Move holiday sessions EARLIER, never later — never let your gap exceed about 72 hours. 2) Schedule celebrations right AFTER dialysis, when potassium and fluid are at their weekly lowest.

Party Food: Enjoy, Taste, or Skip

PARTY FOOD, HIDDEN RISKS

Tasty favorites that can stress your kidneys.

Holiday dishes are often high in sodium, phosphorus, and potassium. Too much can lead to fluid overload and other serious problems.



COMMON PARTY FOODS TO WATCH

 HAM & PROCESSED MEATS Very high in sodium — can cause thirst, swelling, and high blood pressure.  SODIUM	 FRUIT SALAD Often high in potassium and sugar — risky for kidneys and blood sugar.  POTASSIUM	 PANCIT & NOODLES High in sodium and phosphorus from sauces and seasonings.  SODIUM	 FRIED FOODS High in phosphorus additives and unhealthy fats.  PHOSPHORUS	 SOFT DRINKS High in phosphorus and sugar — adds empty calories and fluid retention.  PHOSPHORUS
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SMARTER SWAPS, SAFER CHOICES

-  Choose fresh meats over ham or processed meats.
-  Pick lower-potassium fruits in small portions (apple, grapes, pineapple).
-  Enjoy pancit in smaller servings. Ask for less sauce.
-  Choose grilled, baked, or air-fried options.
-  Water is best. Skip the soft drinks.

PARTY SURVIVAL TIPS



Use a small plate. Control your portions.



Mind the time. Don't go too long between dialysis and feasts.



Stay hydrated within your fluid allowance.



Know your limits. It's okay to say no or enjoy less.



Every patient is different. Talk to your nephrologist or dietitian about the right diet plan for you.



Enjoy the celebration. Protect your kidneys. Small choices. Big difference.

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- **SAFER — normal portions** — steamed rice, grilled fish, plain chicken inasal (no skin, no sauce), fresh lumpia, plain puto or kutsinta.
- **SMALL TASTE ONLY — 2-3 bites, once** — lechon (lean, no skin or sauce), ham & keso de bola (one thin slice), Filipino spaghetti, fruit/buko salad (2 spoonfuls), bibingka, leche flan.
- **SKIP** — dinuguan, kare-kare with bagoong, sisig, chicharon, crispy pata, salted egg, chips & nuts, gravy, all-day sabaw pots.
- **Plate strategy** — half plate rice + safest dishes, then TWO small favorites. One plate, one pass — walang balikan.

The Fruit Trap: "It's Just Fruit" Is How It Starts

THE FRUIT TRAP

Delicious, but easy to overdo.

Many holiday fruits are high in potassium.
Too much can be dangerous for kidney patients.

ENJOY IN MODERATION

Smaller portions, less often.



SMALL PORTIONS

Stick to small servings.



LESS OFTEN

Not every day, especially during the holidays.



KNOW YOUR LIMIT

Follow your diet plan and lab results.



WHY IT MATTERS

High potassium can cause:



Irregular heartbeat



Muscle weakness



Life-threatening complications



RAMBUTAN

High Potassium ↑



LANGSAT / LANZONES

High Potassium ↑



FRUIT SALAD

High Potassium ↑



Love fruits. Protect your kidneys.
Balance is the best gift you can give yourself and your family.



Every patient is different.
Ask your nephrologist or dietitian what fruits are right for you.



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- **The rule** — ONE fruit, ONE serving, ONCE that day — decided before you sit down.
- **Count-and-stop fruits** — rambutan and lanzones: 5 pieces, then walk away. Durian: one section is already a big load. Watermelon and melon count as fluid too.
- **Better choices** — apple, pear, one slice of pineapple, half a small mango, the New Year "12 grapes" (12 grapes, not 12 bunches).

NEVER: star fruit (balimbing) — at any amount

Star fruit contains a toxin (caramboxin) that failing kidneys cannot remove. Even one fruit or one glass of juice can cause unstoppable hiccups, confusion, seizures, and death. Hiccups that will not stop after eating balimbing = go to the ER immediately and say what you ate.

Build Your Fiesta Plate — 8 Steps

THE FIESTA PLATE

Enjoy the celebration. Protect your kidneys.

You can enjoy your favorite holiday foods with a little planning and smart choices.



The Goal:
Balance and moderation.
Small choices today, better tomorrows.

BUILD A KIDNEY-FRIENDLY FIESTA PLATE



1. START WITH SMALL PORTIONS

Begin with a little. You can always choose less.



2. CHOOSE KIDNEY-FRIENDLY PROTEINS

Go for grilled fish, chicken without skin, or lean meats. Avoid processed meats.



3. ADD VEGETABLES

Choose low-potassium veggies like sayote, pechay, baguio beans, or cabbage.



4. ENJOY FRUITS IN MODERATION

Pick lower-potassium fruits and small portions. Avoid fruit salad with lots of syrup.



5. WATCH YOUR DRINKS

Water is best. Limit softdrinks, juices, alcohol, and sweetened beverages.



SMART REMINDERS

- ✓ Stick to your diet and fluid plan.
- ✓ Mind your salt, sauces, and seasonings.
- ✓ Avoid "extra" helpings.
- ✓ Take your medications as prescribed.
- ✓ Enjoy the company, not just the food!

You're in control. **One choice at a time.**



Celebrate with love.
Choose with care.
Protect your kidneys. Enjoy life.



Every patient is different.
Talk to your nephrologist or dietitian for a meal plan that's right for you.



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- **1. Don't arrive starving** — eat a kidney-safe meal before leaving home.
- **2. Bring your binders** — take them WITH the party meal — that is the meal they exist for.
- **3. Survey the whole table first** — choose your two favorites with your eyes, not your stomach.
- **4. Half plate = rice + safest dishes** — then your TWO favorites in small portions.
- **5. One plate, one pass** — sit far from the buffet and the grazing bowls.
- **6. Decide fruit & drink beforehand** — decisions made in advance survive temptation.
- **7. Ready your script** — "Masarap talaga, pero bawal sa dialysis ko — tikim na lang ako para hindi ako ma-ospital sa Pasko!"
- **8. Medicines on schedule** — set phone alarms; never "fix" the morning-after headache with NSAIDs (mefenamic, ibuprofen).

Protect Your Dialysis Schedule



TIMING PEARL

Timing is Everything.

A little planning today for a healthier tomorrow.

Good timing with your dialysis, meals, fluids, and rest can help you enjoy the holidays and protect your kidneys.



TIME IT RIGHT FOR BETTER DAYS



1. SCHEDULE YOUR DIALYSIS

Don't skip sessions.
Book early and confirm your schedule before the holidays.



2. PLAN YOUR MEALS

Eat a kidney-friendly meal before parties.
Choose wisely during celebrations.



3. MANAGE YOUR FLUIDS

Stick to your daily fluid allowance — even when it's tempting to indulge.



4. GET ENOUGH REST

Rest helps your body recover and keeps you strong for the celebrations ahead.



5. TAKE YOUR MEDICATIONS

Don't miss a dose.
Set reminders and bring your meds wherever you go.



ENJOY THE MOMENTS. PROTECT WHAT MATTERS.

Plan ahead. Stay on track.
Make this season wonderful for you and your loved ones.

**Small steps today.
Stronger kidneys tomorrow.**



You are not alone in your kidney journey.
Your care today is their tomorrow.



Every patient is different.
Talk to your nephrologist or dietitian for a plan that's right for you.



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- **By December 1** — check whether Dec 24, 25, 31, or Jan 1 lands on your session day; ask the unit for its holiday schedule early — good slots go fast.
- **Move sessions EARLIER, never later** — if your session falls on the holiday itself, request the day before, not the day after.
- **The smartest party trick** — book a morning slot on Dec 24 / Dec 31 and celebrate that evening — same food, far less danger.
- **Traveling to the province?** — book guest dialysis at the destination BEFORE booking the bus or flight.
- **Never trade a session for a party** — attend after your session, arrive late, leave early, or move the family celebration — your family would rather move the party than visit you in the ICU.

EMERGENCY

Warning Signs — Do NOT Wait for Your Next Session

- Chest heaviness or chest pain; racing, skipping, or irregular heartbeat.
- Muscle weakness or heaviness of the arms and legs — a classic high-potassium sign.
- Shortness of breath, cannot lie flat, frothy cough; sudden swelling with a big weight jump.
- Confusion or extreme drowsiness; numbness or tingling around the lips and fingers.
- Hiccups that will not stop after star fruit — an emergency even if you feel "okay".

Say this at the ER — exact words

"I am a dialysis patient (or: I have stage __ CKD). My last dialysis was on __. I ate a large amount of high-potassium food today. Please check my potassium and do an ECG now."

KIDNEY PATIENT — EMERGENCY CARD

Name: _____

Diagnosis: ☐ CKD stage __ ☐ Hemodialysis ☐ PD

Dialysis days: _____ Dry weight: _____ kg

Dialysis unit & phone: _____

Nephrologist: _____

Allergies: _____

IN EMERGENCY: check serum potassium + ECG immediately. Patient may need urgent dialysis.

Fill out in ink, cut along the border, and laminate. Keep one in your wallet and give one to a family member. An online fillable version is on the guide page.

Pre-Party Checklist

- ☐ Dialysis schedule for the holiday week confirmed — session moved EARLIER if needed
- ☐ Phosphate binders and all medicines in pocket or bag
- ☐ Ate a kidney-safe meal before leaving — not arriving hungry
- ☐ Fruit decision made: which one, how much, once
- ☐ Fluid budget set; small-cup strategy ready
- ☐ "No thank you" script practiced
- ☐ Nearest open ER on a holiday identified; unit phone number saved
- ☐ One family member briefed on the warning signs
- ☐ Weigh yourself the morning after — bring the number to your next session

For your family and hosts

Food is love — and the most loving thing you can do for a kidney patient is make safe eating easy: cook one plain grilled dish, serve sauces on the side, accept their "no" the first time, keep the fruit bowl out of grazing distance, and know the warning signs.

References & full guide

Foley RN et al., N Engl J Med 2011;365:1099-107 (long interdialytic interval)

Ettinger PO et al., Am Heart J 1978 (holiday heart) · Wakasugi M et al., J Ren Nutr 2023

KDOQI Clinical Practice Guideline for Nutrition in CKD: 2020 Update

Full interactive guide (EN · TL · CEB · KAP): williamriveromd.com/guides/surviving-fiestas-holidays-ckd.html

This companion is for general education and does not replace the advice of your own nephrologist and renal dietitian. "Holiday Kidney Syndrome" is a descriptive teaching term used in this practice, not an official diagnosis. © 2026 W. G. M. Rivero, MD — williamriveromd.com